

both a restless desire for something you don't have and a dissatisfaction with your stuff, status, and situation. All the opposites of contentment can be found in both extremes.

I have this image of Lizzie McGuire (from the Disney show in 2001 for all my non-Millennials) with a cartoon version of herself on each shoulder. On one shoulder stands her perfect self and on the other shoulder stands her unhinged self. Each version is pleading with the true Lizzie's head in the middle, trying to persuade her to take their advice in the complicated conundrum she found herself in with friends, boys, parents, you name it! The early 2000s loved this specific depiction of our inner monologue and the competing extremes we often need to choose between. In the end, rarely did Lizzie ever fully take either one's advice. Usually it was some combination of the two, mixed with her own creativity.

And here we are, much like Lizzie. On one end we have a hustle culture telling us to work harder, get the job, take the promotion, and start a side business. Hustle, hustle, hustle. On the other end we have another voice steering us toward apathy. Mumbling "What's even the point," whether you work hard or not, there's no such thing as getting ahead. Taxes will happen every year, the debt isn't going anywhere, the house is just gonna get dirty again, and your work will never be valued. Give up. Lean into complacency.

AHH!

True to the sitcom, this is the part where Lizzie screams. I'm screaming a little too.

If I learned anything from Lizzie, it was to take a little from both sides, mix in my own creativity, and find the radical middle. For us, that's contentment without complacency. We don't have to let go of our aspirations and goals, and we're also allowed to take it easy every once in a while. We can train ourselves to take hold of both ends of the spectrum and allow the tension to guide us. We can be pleased with our circumstances without finding ourselves in a place of stagnation or exhaustion.

And finding contentment in the things money both can and can't buy is what gives space to pause and take breaks, while recognizing our responsibility to live into our full capacity.

Of course, contentment is a hard thing to measure or give a five-step guide to achieving. We can't *will* ourselves toward being content. No amount of strong-arming to just "be satisfied" will work. It's such an